The Hundred and Eight Names of the Venerable Noble Tārā

Āryatārābhaṭṭārikānāmāṣṭaśataka · Toh 1000 · Derge Kangyur
རྗེ་བཙུན་འཕགས་མ་སགྲོལ་མའི་མཚན་བར་རྒྱ་བརྒྱད་པ་ཞེས་བྱ།

The Hundred and Eight Names of the Venerable Noble Tārā, known in Sanskrit as the Āryatārābhaṭṭārikānāmāṣṭaśataka and in Tibetan as rje btsun 'phags ma sgrol ma'i mtshan brgya rtsa brgyad pa, is a short devotional text in praise of the female buddha Tārā, renowned as a swift protector and liberator from fear and suffering. After an opening homage, the text is set on Mount Potala, a richly described paradise of flowering trees, waterfalls, singing birds, and celestial beings, frequented by sages and hosts of bodhisattvas. Against this backdrop it presents a litany of Tārā's epithets, a form of recitation traditionally valued for invoking her blessings and protection. It is Toh 1000 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the shorter tantric and dhāraṇī-style texts centered on the praise and invocation of a deity.

In the language of India: ārya thā rā bhaṭṭā ra ka nā ma aṣṭa śa ta kaṃ. In the language of Tibet: The Hundred and Eight Names of the Venerable Noble Tārā.

Homage to the venerable noble Tārā.

In glorious, delightful Potala,
adorned with minerals of many kinds,
spread with trees of many kinds,
resounding with the calls of many birds,
loud with the roar of many waterfalls,
teeming with wild beasts of many kinds,
filled all around with the fragrance
of flowers of many varieties,
rich in delightful fruits of many kinds,
with the humming song of bees,
where kinnaras sing sweet songs,
filled with elephants in rut,
where hosts of vidyādharas and siddhas
and gandharvas too sing songs,
a place frequented always and well
by sages free of desire,
by other hosts of bodhisattvas,

by the lords of the ten grounds,
by goddesses such as noble Tārā,
and by thousands of queens of knowledge,
there, surrounded by other hosts of wrathful kings,
by Hayagrīva and the rest,
striving for the benefit of all beings,
the Blessed One Avalokiteśvara
dwells, and so that place is glorious.
On a seat of lotus heart, the seat of the Sage,
he who has great austerity,
endowed with loving-kindness and compassion,
was seated, teaching the Dharma
to a great assembly of gods.
There the one seated near him rose up,
Vajrapāṇi, of great strength,
and, being supremely compassionate,
made this request to Avalokiteśvara:
"O Sage who calms the fears
of thieves, snakes, lions, fire,
elephants, tigers and water,
tell me, great Sage, that by which beings,
sunk in the ocean of saṃsāra,
bound by the noose of saṃsāra,
are freed from the stains
of attachment, hatred and delusion."

The Protector of the World said this:
the glorious Avalokiteśvara,
giving understanding to Vajrapāṇi,
spoke these pleasing words:
"Listen, Lord of the Secret Ones!
She who arose through the power
of the aspiration of the protector Amitābha,
whom I know as the Mother of the World,
endowed with great compassion,
she strives to rescue beings.
Like the rising sun,

the radiance of her face like the full moon,
she illumines all of these:
humans together with gods, and asuras.
She makes the three worlds tremble;
she terrifies yakṣas and rākṣasas.
In her hand is a blue utpala lotus;
she says, 'Fear not, fear not!'
She abides, soaring in the sky.
'In order truly to protect beings,
when the eon of weapons came
and many kinds of terror raged,
the Victors brought me forth.
Through the mere remembrance of my names
I protect all beings.
From the ocean of many fears
I carry all beings across.
Therefore in the world
the hosts of Victors proclaim me Tārā.'"

Joining his palms together,
seated before him, he made this request,
remaining there with reverence:
"Please speak the hundred and eight names
that the Victor proclaimed of old,
which delight the protectors, the lords of the ten grounds,
and the bodhisattvas,
which remove sin, and increase
merit, good fortune and fame,
which increase treasure and wealth,
which destroy all diseases,
which bestow glory and auspiciousness,
which increase health and life.
Meditating on love for beings,
proclaim them, great Sage!"

When this had been asked, the Blessed One,
the Lord Avalokiteśvara, laughed broadly.
Gazing out upon the supreme ones,

he radiated love such as this,
and made a gesture with his right hand.
He who bears the marks of merit
spoke to the one of very great wisdom:
"Excellent, excellent, great ascetic,
one-pointedly loving toward all beings!
Listen, people of great fortune:
whoever among humans proclaims this
will truly become a lord of wealth,
will be wholly freed from all diseases,
will be truly endowed with every sovereignty;
untimely death will surely be burned away,
and at death they will go to Sukhāvatī.
I shall explain these names.
Saṅgha of the gods, listen to me!
Rejoice in this,
and, having become well restrained, offer praise.

oṃ Virtuous One, of great splendor,
Healer of the world, of great renown,
Sarasvatī, the wide-eyed,
who increases wisdom, glory and understanding,
Healer and Nourisher, svāhā.
She whose aspect is oṃ, who takes forms at will,
striving for the benefit of all beings,
Victorious One who rescues from battle,
the goddess Prajñāpāramitā,
noble Tārā, the delightful,
she of drum and conch, the Abundant,
Queen of Knowledge, of sweet speech,
Moon-faced, the Great White One,
the Invincible, clad in yellow garments,
Great Illusion, the Great White One,
of great strength, gone beyond,
Great Harsh One, Great Fierce One,
who destroys minds full of hatred,
Utterly Peaceful, of peaceful form,

Victorious One of blazing light,
bearing a banner of a garland of lightning,
holding sword, wheel and bow as weapons,
the Crusher, the Paralyzer, the Black One,
Night, the Black One, who moves by night,
Protector, Bewilderer, the Peaceful One,
the Lovely, the Auspicious, the Soaring One,
Brahmāṇī and the Lady of the Veda,
the Secret One who dwells in caves,
the Auspicious, who accomplishes aims, the Peaceful,
Knower of all born, swift as thought,
the Skull-bearer, of great force,
Brahmā's consort, the Blissful, unconquered by others,
Great Caravan Leader, abode of compassion,
who shows the path to those who are lost,
Giver of the supreme, the Giver, the Teacher,
who in a woman's form overpowers beyond measure,
the Mountain Dweller and the Yoginī,
the Accomplished, the Fierce, the Immortal Nectar,
the Gentle, the Wealthy, the Meritorious,
of great fortune, of good fortune, of lovely appearance,
the Ender, the Terrifier, the Frightener,
of great fame and great vows,
striving single-mindedly for the benefit of beings,
the Refuge, upright toward the devoted,
Lady of Speech, peaceful and subtle,
the Eternal, the All-pervading, who follows after,
Accomplisher of all aims, the Excellent,
who keeps secret, Healer, Giver of wealth,
the Fearless, the Meritorious, Gautamī,
the very nature of Lord Avalokiteśvara.
These hundred and eight names
are renowned as bringing benefit;
they are supremely wondrous and secret.

Hard to find even in the realm of the gods,
they bring good fortune and make one fortunate;

they destroy every kind of poison;
she is the one who pacifies every disease,
she who grants happiness to all beings.
Whatever wise person reads them three times,
in meditative equipoise and having made himself clean,
will before long
attain even the glory of kingship.
Even one who is always miserable will become happy;
the poor will become rich;
the dull will gain great wisdom
and become keen of mind, without a doubt.
The bound will be freed from their bonds;
they will also win in lawsuits;
enemies will become friends.
From horned beasts and fanged beasts,
from battles in dire straits, hard to win,
and from the turmoil of various fears,
by remembering these names
one is rescued from all fears,
one is rescued from untimely death,
and that person attains renown.
Birth as a human becomes meaningful
through the benefit of this alone.
Whoever rises early
and proclaims these names
will be endowed with long life,
and that person will rejoice in glory.
Gods, nāgas, yakṣas,
gandharvas and kaṭapūtanas,
bhūtas, executioners, rākṣasas,
mātṛkās of harsh mind,
yakṣiṇīs and pretas,
unmādas and the great grahas,
shadow-oppressors and apasmāras,
piśācas and the like,
vetālas and all the various others,
instigators and others of hostile mind,

will not even step upon his shadow;
how then could they contend with him?
Hostile beings will be bound.
He will not be struck by disease and the like.
He will have wealth, enjoyments and good qualities,
and his sons and grandsons will increase.
Wise, he will remember his past lives;
he will be of noble family and pleasing to behold,
radiant and clear of speech,
and he will know all the treatises.
He will properly attend upon and honor spiritual friends,
and be adorned with the mind of awakening;
and wherever he is born,
he will never be forsaken by the buddhas.

Spoken by the glorious noble Avalokiteśvara. The Hundred and Eight Names of the Venerable Noble Tārā is complete.

Translator's Notes

• The line rendered "There the one seated near him rose up" reads □□□□□□□□, which as written ("incense") makes little sense here. It is taken as □□□□□□□□, "seated nearby." Several epithets in the name list are terse and could correspond to more than one Sanskrit name. They are translated by meaning rather than restored to Sanskrit; for example, "Lady of Speech" may stand for Vāgīśvarī and "Great Illusion" for Mahāmāyā. In particular, the line rendered "the Lovely, the Auspicious, the Soaring One" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is obscure. The line rendered "the very nature of Lord Avalokiteśvara" reads □□□□□□□□□□□□, which is probably corrupt. It could instead mean "by Lord Avalokiteśvara himself," introducing the closing lines. Here it is kept as the last epithet.
• "Shadow-oppressors" renders a class of spirit whose Sanskrit name I cannot identify with confidence; it is translated literally. "Apasmāras" renders the Tibetan "those who cause forgetting," the usual equivalent of that class of seizing spirit. "Instigators" is likewise a literal rendering of a term whose exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain.

Colophon

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consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.